

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR



Doling Out Dreams

JAIPUR Rajasthan Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje doubles up as finance minister with tactical finesse, especially when it comes to presenting the state budget. So it came as no surprise when she doled out a populist budget for the fifth time in a row, this time keeping in mind the not so far elections in November.

The reason behind early budget presentation on February 25—much before the Union Budget—

was Raje wanting as much time as she could to prepare for the polls. However, insiders claim this was because the chief minister knew what the Centre would offer to the taxpayer and she took convenient chunks from it and presented them as her own sops. "States should get more devolution of their rightful funding. In some conditions where the Centre wants to share 50 per cent money, I have opted to bear the

FOR THE MASSES: Raje's budget is people friendly entire cost so as to call it my scheme," said Raje while presenting the Rs 180-crore surplus budget with fiscal deficit pegged well below 3 per cent of SGDP.

Raje's sops cut across gender, education, caste, government employees and traders. Reservation for women in Panchayati Raj institutions has been raised from 33 per cent to 50 per cent with incentives for students from the lower strata of society. There are also special incentives for colleges and teachers. For government employees there's a 20 per cent salary hike along with another instalment of dearness allowance and other sops for police and small-time traders like fruit and vegetable vendors. Cable TV operators have been taxed while entertainment tax in cinemas has been cut. Clearly, Raje seems to be keyed in on pleasing the BJP votebank in her state on as many counts as she can as she gears up to fight for another term in office. **by Rohit Parihar**

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Shiv Sena MP **Prakash Paranjpe**, 60. He was a three-time Lok Sabha member from Thane constituency in Mumbai.

WON: By shuttler **Anand Pawar**, the Austrian Open Men's Singles title. He defeated Vladislav Druzchenko of Ukraine in Vienna. He is the second Indian after the late Syed Modi to lift the title.

WON: By **Shagun Sarabhal**, 20, the Miss India



Worldwide 2008 crown in Johannesburg. She is a homeopathy student from Mumbai.

DIED: **V.P. Devulgaonkar**, 91, senior Karnataka Congress leader. He played an active role in the Hyderabad liberation movement.

DIED: **Sagar Singh**, 89, former president of Banaras Bar Association. He was a socialist leader and Hindi littérateur also.

VIS-A-VIS **ABDUR R. MOLLAH** West Bengal land reforms minister **versus** **VASUNDHARA RAJE** Rajasthan chief minister

“
Marwaris adopt unfair means to get work done. It is because of them that corruption is rampant.
”



SAURABH SINGH

“
His remark is against the spirit of the Constitution. Marwaris have added to the economic strength of West Bengal.
”

EPILOGUE: After Maharashtra In the west, regional acerbity moves east to West Bengal.